

Happy 'Super Tuesday'

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By GABRIEL GAVIN BONJOUR

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BONJOUR — et bonne Fête Nationale to France. I'm Gabriel Gavin and I'll be marking Bastille Day with the great and good of the Brussels French establishment tonight at a reception ... and a screening of Les Bleus' World Cup semifinal game against Spain.

In today's Playbook:

- Ursula von der Leyen heads to Ukraine, as Kyiv's EU membership push gets underway.
- Why Donald Trump shouldn't try to divide EU countries on trade.
- Faces in the crowd: Jovita Neliupšienė, Thomas Byrne, Dubravka Šuica, Tamás Sulyok, Viktor Orbán, Marta Kos, Taras Kachka, António Costa, Mark Rutte, Manfred Weber, Assita Kanko, Stephen Doughty and many more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Sarah unpack "Super Tuesday," when Ukraine, Moldova, Albania and Montenegro will edge closer to EU membership.

DRIVING THE DAY

IS EUROPE GETTING BIGGER? The EU will today take the biggest step in recent years toward letting new countries join, paving the way for the 27-member bloc to expand to 28, 29 or even 30 members by the end of this decade.

Cluster chuck: At meetings in Brussels today, Ukraine and Moldova will have the chance to open their second-ever negotiating "cluster" that will trigger reforms on foreign policy, trade, security and development aid. Montenegro (which plans to be the EU's 28th member by 2028) and Albania will close "chapters" — the components of the wider groupings, or clusters — in what will mark a major step forward.

"All four accession frontrunners taking major steps forward on one day," was the snapshot provided to Playbook by Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos. "That's why we're calling it 'Super Tuesday.' You have to go back well over 20 years to when so many [cluster ceremonies] were held on the same day."

“The momentum for enlargement is building. It is now undeniable to see that Ukraine, Moldova, Montenegro and Albania will soon become EU member states,” Kos will say today, adding that if candidate countries put in the work, Brussels will make sure progress continues toward full membership.

Progress on enlargement had been stuck for years, with former Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orbán holding to ransom the progress of Ukraine and Moldova; other national governments feared new members might backslide and become “Hungary 2.0.” Brussels is now hoping that Hungarian Prime Minister Péter Magyar can fix one of those problems and that new guardrails under development will fix the other — although Budapest is still dragging its feet on opening all of the clusters.

Inertia and prejudice: Ukraine’s Deputy Prime Minister Taras Kachka told POLITICO’s Zoya Sheftalovich and Nicholas Vinocur that there’s still a “lack of feeling of urgency among all 27 member states, and thus the lack of unanimity for opening all five clusters.” For that, he blamed “a political inertia and a lot of prejudice that still exist[s] in Hungarian society.”

Getting better: Kachka went on to say that there’s now a “really good dialogue” with the new government in Budapest and more is being done to sell expanded membership to the public.

Watch this space: But with Brussels increasingly seeing enlargement as a geopolitical imperative, more “Mega Mondays,” “Super Tuesdays” and “Fantastic Fridays” could ultimately see the EU get its new members before long ...

TRAVEL SCOOP: European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen will travel to Ukraine on Wednesday to discuss both enlargement and defense, an official working on the trip confirmed to Playbook.

BIG AND BREAKING

NEW TOLLMaster IN TOWN: President Donald Trump announced the U.S. would take over the strategic Strait of Hormuz, threatening to skim 20 percent off the value of cargo going through the waterway — an outcome the EU has consistently warned against. Meanwhile, the U.S. military carried out a third consecutive night of strikes against Iran, Reuters reports .

HEAT WAVE AND WILDFIRES: Europe’s heat wave last month was responsible for the deaths of up to 14,000 Europeans, according to new statistics released by scientists. Meanwhile, Spanish authorities say five Britons, three Belgians and one national from France and Spain are among the 13 victims of one of Spain’s deadliest wildfires in recent times, France 24 reports .

SANCTIONS NO-DEAL: EU foreign ministers have left Brussels without a deal on either a proposed package of fresh Russia sanctions or sanctions on “extremist” Israeli ministers. A decision on the EU’s trade arrangements with illegal West Bank settlements was pushed to Wednesday .

Regrets: Top EU diplomat Kaja Kallas acknowledged the setback on the Russian package on Monday afternoon, Koen Verhelst reports. Wednesday is the last day to lock in an oil price cap, which is a component of the proposed sanctions. Bloomberg reports that Trump plans to support a Russia sanctions bill championed by the late Senator Lindsey Graham.

GOVERNMENT CLOSES IN ON Sulyok: Hungary’s new government voted Monday to oust the country’s Orbán-appointed President Tamás Sulyok, who now has five days to sign the amendment into law or

face impeachment.

PLAYBOOK INTERVIEW

TRANSATLANTIC TROUBLES: Europe's top diplomat in Washington has a blunt message for the Trump administration: Turning EU countries against each other in a trade fight is easier said than done.

All for one: Speaking with our Illinois Playbook colleague Shia Kapos about Trump's threat to cut all trade with Spain, EU Ambassador to the U.S. Jovita Neliupšienė pointed to a basic obstacle: The EU "is a single market. It's very difficult to cut [out] Spain."

Focus on Turnberry: The ambassador's broader plea was for Washington to stick to the EU-U.S. trade agreement signed in Scotland almost a year ago, rather than reopen hostilities. "As much as we can actually stick to the [Turnberry] deal, the better," she said. Otherwise, "all the possible options are on the table."

The big risk, Neliupšienė argued, is the unpredictability surrounding U.S. policy. "The biggest problem for both European ... [and] American companies is volatility," she said. Businesses making long-term industrial investments need "a very stable, predictable environment."

Buy European — but not just European: Neliupšienė said Europe's push to strengthen its own industry doesn't mean shutting out America. Between 30 and 40 percent of European defense procurement already comes from the U.S., she said, and that increases to more than 60 percent for weapons bought for Ukraine.

Not alone: "Being stronger or clearing your supply chain does not mean that you have to do that alone," Neliupšienė said, pointing to U.S.-EU co-production — preferably on European soil.

Beijing shift: Europe's view of China is hardening as economic concerns collide with security fears, Neliupšienė said. Brussels is trying to strike a balance in using trade-defense tools to guarantee fair competition and market access, raising those concerns "at the highest level" with Beijing. "China is one of the biggest economic suppliers for Russia, which actually helps to continue the war" in Ukraine, she said.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

Today a select group of ministers from around the EU will meet in Brussels. But what goes on at the General Affairs Council? It involves ministers with responsibility for EU affairs (in some cases that's the foreign minister). One of the main tasks is to prepare for European Councils (the meetings of EU leaders) and to follow up on those meetings. That's not the case today, as the ministers will hear a presentation by the Irish presidency on its priorities. The GAC also works on topics such as EU enlargement, the long-term budget and simplification of EU rules.

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BIG BUDGET BATTLE

HALF A TRILLION PROBLEMS: Ireland will today tell EU ministers how it plans to tackle a bitter divide over the EU's long-term budget and deliver a deal that can unite those that stand to gain money and those footing the bill.

Big bucks: In its role as president of the Council of the EU, Dublin is expected to present a new "nego-box" on the seven-year, €2 trillion budget in time for a leaders' summit in October. While the overall structure is largely settled, some net contributors want as much as €450 billion shaved off the overall bill, two national officials said. Net recipients of funds are also digging in their heels.

The stakes are high. If the compromise is too far away from a potential agreement, European Council President António Costa will be pressed for time to sell it to capitals and the negotiation could run past the end-of-year deadline, potentially leading to delays in delivering the money.

"We're going to work really hard. We have to look at what's possible ...," Ireland's Europe Minister Thomas Byrne told Playbook. There will be a flurry of talks "over the summer and into the early autumn" as well as an informal ministerial meeting in Dublin in September before the October European Council, he said. The Irish ambassador will hold bilaterals with counterparts next week to get the ball rolling, diplomats said.

Sharpening the knife: The like-minded frugal countries that want to see their contributions reduced are working to organize a summit of their own to refine their negotiating strategy and knock the budget back down to size, two diplomats confirmed.

Getting creative: A shadow proposal, yet to be formally presented but attributed to the French, would see new revenue streams to fund EU schemes agreed and paid for voluntarily by EU members, three envoys said. That would create an opt-in system and avoid some of the battle over the bill. But France has not yet confirmed it will push ahead with the suggestions.

****Six months that will shape Europe's agenda.** Ireland inherits a packed legislative calendar and difficult political choices. Our Research & Analysis Division explains what will move, what may stall, and why it matters. Read the full report for the complete analysis .**

4 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

HOT ATOMS: Nuclear power is one answer to tackling climate change. But a hotter planet means France is less able to run its flagship nuclear power plants, with three reactors put out of business by soaring temperatures .

GREEN LIGHT FOR UKRAINE MISSILES: Nine European countries have agreed to back an ambitious Ukrainian effort to develop a domestic missile defense system that, if successful, would reduce reliance on U.S. technology.

BUT NO DITCHING THE DON: Europe talks a good game on ending its dependence on American weaponry. But the continent isn't ready to replace U.S. defense assets , Germany's air force chief tells POLITICO.

CRIMEA RIVER: Ukraine's Russian-occupied peninsula was once a defense asset for Putin — now it's become a liability .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny, with a top temperature of 33C.

EUROPE'S GRAYING FUTURE: The EU's population will peak in 2029 and is projected to fall from 450.6 million today to 398.8 million by 2100, according to the European Commission's latest demography report, to be released later today and previewed by Playbook's Zoya Sheftalovich.

The most startling stat: There were 6.8 million births in Europe in 1964, and only 3.5 million in 2024. An aging, shrinking population will strain labor markets, health care, public finances and depopulating regions, though Brussels says longer lives could also support growth if governments invest in skills, care, housing and higher workforce participation.

Uh-oh: "Europe's demographic transformation is not a challenge for tomorrow — it is happening now. Our population has reached its peak and will gradually decline," said the EU commissioner responsible for demography, Dubravka Šuica. "Europe has the tools to respond ... If we act early and together, demographic change can become one of Europe's greatest opportunities."

BELGIAN TAX RETURN DEADLINE EXTENDED: Great news for anyone who has yet to file a tax return: the Belgian government is extending the deadline to complete your online return from July 15 to July 19. It's not that the federal public service finance department was feeling uncharacteristically generous — officials noticed that lots of people logging on to MyMinFin's Tax-on-web platform had been dealing with technical issues.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Why Chancellor Friedrich Merz can't afford to make any mistakes over coming days.

London: Keir Starmer's farewell tour may almost be over, but a legislative breakthrough will today place the outgoing prime minister front and center of the Hillsborough law .

Paris: There will be around 30 heads of state and government in the stands to celebrate Bastille Day — just don't call it a farewell to Emmanuel Macron.

Washington PM: The feud between the U.S. and Iran over who controls the Strait of Hormuz has unwound most of the progress in the memorandum of understanding they signed.

AGENDA

— General Affairs Council, at 10 a.m. Read the agenda here .

— 28th Accession Conference with Montenegro; 9th Accession Conference with Albania, 3rd Accession Conference with Ukraine.

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen, Council President António Costa, NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte and other leaders participate in Bastille Day celebrations in Paris.

— Costa meets Indian government delegation, including Minister of External Affairs Subrahmanyam Jaishankar.

- Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič receives German Chamber of Commerce and Industry CEO Helena Melnikov and UAE Minister of State for Europe Lana Nusseibeh.
- Šefčovič and U.K. Minister of State for Europe Stephen Doughty sign the Agreement between the EU and the U.K. on Gibraltar.
- EU Foreign Policy Chief Kaja Kallas meets Jaishankar, Moldovan Foreign Minister Mihai Popoi and Spanish Foreign Minister José Manuel Albares Bueno.
- Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis meets Acting Moldovan Prime Minister Eugen Osmochescu.
- International Partnerships Commissioner Jozef Síkela meets Austrian Foreign Minister Beate Meinl-Reisinger.
- Agriculture Commissioner Christophe Hansen receives Indian Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal.
- European Parliament debates conditions and procedures for unfreezing EU funds allocated to Hungary. Opening statements at 9:30 a.m. Watch .

BIRTHDAYS

EPP leader in the European Parliament Manfred Weber; MEP Assita Kanko; BCG's Graham Ackerman; journalist Daniel Strauss; Italy's Ambassador to Ethiopia Sem Fabrizi; New York Times' Matina Stevis-Gridneff; POLITICO alumnus Frank Witte; Marine Uldry, from the European Disability Forum. It's Bastille Day in France.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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